

SPIRITUAL SAGACITY 101

*Recognising and
Resisting Spiritual
Manipulation and
Abuse*



Charlatans, Carnal Christians and Church Cults

We are now fully in the **Dangerous Dispensation** regarding which the Scriptures have warned us as Saints and Sons. And one of the perilous patterns of these times is the rise of evil men, liars and deceivers, who hide under the cloak of our Christian Faith, to deceive, derail and destroy.

Thus, in this age, **divine discernment must become a conscious competence for every believer**. We ought to move towards maturity in the things of God through diligent discipleship, Scripture study, and spiritual sensitivity, so that the enemy does not take advantage!

Here are Significant Spiritual Insights for you:



01.

The Crucible of Christlike Character!

In 2 Timothy 3:1-5, Apostle Paul warned of a certain calibre of people - *"But know this, that in the last days perilous times will come: For men will be lovers of themselves, lovers of money, boasters, proud, blasphemers, disobedient to parents, unthankful, unholy, unloving, unforgiving, slanderers, without self-control, brutal, despisers of good, traitors, headstrong, haughty, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God, having a form of godliness but denying its power. And from such people turn away!"*

The first easy sign of the Charlatans, Fraudsters and Profiteering Prophets is their character. Whenever you observe the absence of Christlike Character, even in the presence of Public Persona and Charming Charisma, let your spiritual senses open up.

Even if it is hidden in the beginning, when you start to see what you cannot defend in Scriptures; then pay more attention to know what the Spirit of God shows you. They may seem to love God, but will not seek to do His Will. They may speak "Christianese" but will twist the Bible to support their ungodly ways.

02.

Women as Perfect Preys?

In 2 Timothy 3:6-7, Apostle Paul continued – “For of this sort are those who creep into households and make captives of gullible women loaded down with sins, led away by various lusts, always learning and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth.”

Painfully, many women have been preys of false teachers, fake apostles and strange heretics over time, and here are some of the top reasons:

1. **Voice of Emotions** became louder than the Voice of God's Spirit
2. **Women are often in search of answers** while standing in the gap for their marriages and families
3. Women acquired **dysfunctional submission** by witnessing their mothers model unhealthy honour to spiritual authorities
4. Many women serve in Church and Ministries for years, **without building intimacy with God**, thus, no true spiritual maturity
5. **Waiting seasons** (for marriage, children etc) have led women into the hands of sorcerers and spiritual magicians in the name of God
6. A high tendency for **hero worship** in the name of honour
7. Need for **community + connections** could weaken their discernment.

03.

WANTED: Wise Women!

In 2 Timothy 1:5-6 – “When I call to remembrance the [b]genuine faith that is in you, which dwelt first in your grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice, and I am persuaded is in you also. Therefore I remind you to stir up the gift of God which is in you through the laying on of my hands.”

I thank God because our dispensation is filled with wise women, who will awaken generational faith and stir up God’s gift. We need to move more like Kingdom Women who walk in wisdom, establish strong boundaries, focus on divine assignments and take charge of our territories.

When women walk in wisdom, these are strong attributes we demonstrate:

- we seek to protect what God has kept in our care
- we mind our business and focus on God’s divine priorities for our lives
- we obey the Word of God and build godly character
- we are spiritually sensitive and wait for clarity when unsure
- we guard access to our atmospheres and spaces
- we seek to build a legacy of faith for our families
- we take care of our bodies and minds as vessels for God’s glory
- we separate ourselves from workers of iniquity

Yes and Amen!



04.

Carnality is Evil in Business Casual!

Romans 8:6-8 boldly declares thus – *“For to be carnally minded is death, but to be spiritually minded is life and peace. Because the carnal mind is enmity against God; for it is not subject to the law of God, nor indeed can be. So then, those who are in the flesh cannot please God.”*

I know too many believers who underestimate the power of carnality in obstructing God’s move in their lives. Carnality is like **EVIL in Business Casual**, because it looks casual, but it means business!

Carnal Christians are easily deceived, because they practice habitual sins, are not consistently led by the Spirit and thus, often dull of hearing.

When you are carnal, you will

- *be moved by what you see, hear and feel*
- *be desperate to belong in certain circles, follow after popular people or be perceived in a particular way by others*
- *seek prophecy and signs, more than the Presence and Scripture*
- *believe lies that appear and appeal like the Truth*
- *desire to impress people, more than to please the Lord*
- *hunger for spiritual encounters, instead of the Father’s heart*
- *love to be “deep” in mysteries, but unwilling to Christian disciplines*



05.

Discerning Doctrinal Deviations

In 2 Timothy 4:3-4, Apostle Paul says *“For the time will come when people will not endure sound doctrine, but according to their own desires, because they have itching ears, they will heap up for themselves teachers; and they will turn their ears away from the truth, and be turned aside to fables.”*

With the rise of para-church ministries, and the leverage of media-driven platforms – which are blessings to the Body, we also observe the rise of Doctrinal Deviations from the Gospel of our Lord Jesus Christ.

Some dimensions of deviations that exist in these times are:

1. **Immature Ministers** not yet schooled in the whole counsel of God
2. **Self-help psychologists** and philosophers with Biblical branding
3. **Doctrinal Imbalance**, incompleteness or incoherence
4. **“Miracle” merchants**, money movers and magicians under the guise of God’s name
5. **Heretic Teachings** (that deviate from or attack the True Gospel)
6. **False Prophets**, Teachers and Apostles (spiritual fraudsters)
7. **Church Cults**

Let us explore some of the strongest signs of Church Cults >>>



06.

Church Cults are on the Rise!

In 2 Corinthians 11:13-15, Apostle Paul says “for such are false apostles, deceitful workers, transforming themselves into apostles of Christ. And no wonder! For Satan himself transforms himself into an angel of light. Therefore it is no great thing if his ministers also transform themselves into ministers of righteousness, whose end will be according to their works.”

Church Cults are extremely dangerous because they are demonic centres of spiritual manipulation, abuse and isolation; but not quickly discovered because they are branded as “prophetic” in operation.

Some of the standout signs of Church Cults are:

- There is a **LEADER with special access to God** that the others do not have, and hears God for the people
- **“Prophetic” words, visions and instructions** are stronger, and override the Word of God as revealed in Scripture
- **Heavy secrecy of activities** because of the “weight of glory” that God has given to them, which must be “treasured” and not “shared”
- **Fear, threats and coercion** are tools of maintaining submission
- Those who **leave the group are excommunicated** and vilified as backsliders, who will not be able to find “purpose” anywhere else.

07.

Church Cults are on the Rise Contd.

Some of the standout signs of Church Cults are:

- **The Leader often “over-shepherds”** by exerting undue influence over their personal information, resources, family, assets etc.
- **Strong stratification exists**, where there are the “most anointed”, the favourites, the leaders’ preferred, the “last borns” etc.
- **Members are often required to isolate themselves** from loved ones (who stand in the way of their “calling”) – *divorce, separation, exit from media, withdrawal from local assemblies, relocations etc.*
- **Group’s practices and beliefs are sometimes extraordinary, strange or totally unique** to them. These beliefs may have “Biblical backing”, but will not align to Scriptures, but cannot be questioned.
- Members are told that **they can only fulfill their destiny** if they stay submitted to the leader and remain in the “ministry”
- There is often **sexual, financial, verbal and spiritual abuse** – especially from the leader(s).
- **Presence of special revelation** that may outrightly defy the doctrines of Scripture or attack other ministries
- **Deception, lies, pretension, and fables** are abundant
- They often **consume your time** in never-ending cycles of activities.

08.

Honour VS. Hero Worship

There is absolutely a Scriptural instruction to honour our leaders! In 1 Thessalonians 5:12-13, we are admonished to *“those who labor among you, and are over you in the Lord and admonish you, and to esteem them very highly in love for their work’s sake.”*

Yet, it matters to understand the difference between Honour and Hero Worship, because Apostle Paul warned the Church this way in 1 Corinthians 3:4-7 *“For when one says, ‘I am of Paul,’ and another, ‘I am of Apollos,’ are you not carnal? Who then is Paul, and who is Apollos, but ministers through whom you believed, as the Lord gave to each one? I planted, Apollos watered, but God gave the increase. So then neither he who plants is anything, nor he who waters, but God who gives the increase.”*

A major reason the people of God struggle to recognise and resist doctrinal deviations, character confusions and master manipulations is that many are hero-worshipping so much, till they cannot hear God warning us.

Let’s explore a few differences between Honour and Hero Worshipping.



09.

Honour VS. Hero Worship Highlights

	Honour	Hero Worship
1	Honour acts based on a revelation from God and His Word concerning the person.	Hero Worship acts based on an image built in your heart concerning the person.
2	Honour is an allocation of weight bestowed on a person, in response to the office they occupy before God, and ultimately as an act of Honour to God.	Hero Worship is often an exaggerated response to a person's position, based on your perception of their privilege, prestige, power or prosperity etc.
3	Honour produces followership that is according to Christ (imitating them as they imitate Christ).	Produces followership that is according to the Carnal Man (imitating them to become like them).
4	Honour can separate a leader's character flaws as part of a growth process vs when it is a pattern of persistent sinfulness.	Hero Worship is either deeply disappointed by the character flaws of a leader in growth or will blindly cover and defend sinfulness.
5	Honour maintains a reverence for the Word of God as final authority	Esteems the words of a man as first resort, final authority, or most significant consideration
6	Honour seeks an opportunity to serve , give and help the leader.	Primarily seeks an opportunity to receive , or connect for advantage.
7	Honour for forerunners strengthens identity and preserve prototypes .	Hero Worship produces copycats , who lose their originality to be remade in the likeness of their idols

10.

Winning Wisdom: What You Must Do!

2 Timothy 3:13-14 is true! *“Evil men and impostors will grow worse and worse, deceiving and being deceived. But you must continue in the things which you have learned and been assured of, knowing from whom you have learned them.”*

Beloved, the darkness is still going to grow darker, and you have a responsibility to deepen your depths and strengthen yourself in God, so that you can withstand the temptations of our time. You will prevail!

These are simple strategies for today's believers:

- **Join / remain a Bible-Believing Church**, where Christ is loved, the Word of God is preached in truth, and the Spirit bears witness with your spirit, for you to be established there.
- **Prayerfully make your decisions about the ministry / ministries** that you support, serve in and belong to. Ask a more mature Christian to pray with you regarding this important decision.
- **Be careful about who you listen to.** Because teachings are available on YouTube does not mean they are approved by God as part of your Spiritual Feeding System.

Winning Wisdom: What You Must Do!

- **Consider reviewing your partnership** with any ministry, group or community where your spirit has become uneasy, your mind feels confused or your actions are no longer aligned to the Word of God. Speak to a mature believer about your experience.
- **Build a Strong Personal Devotion System** in your life, where you consistently study the Scriptures, spend time in prayers, hear from the Holy Spirit and walk in obedience to God.
- **Invest in Ministry Training** if you sense a call to ministry. Do not step out ahead of the Lord's pruning and preparation regarding the assignment He has for you. Your preparation will save you and those who will hear you.
- **Spend time in prayers and intercession** for yourself, your family, your local assembly and the Body of Christ. Pray that God's people are preserved from dogs who take advantage of the simple-minded.
- **Disciple Younger Believers** and continue to walk with them for their spiritual development.



Winning Wisdom: What You Must Do!

- **Be Careful about those you follow online.** Be intentional about those whom you give access to your minds through social media. Run an audit of the prominent voices you follow, and carefully weigh their values, doctrine and character.
- **Practice Keen Observation.** If something feels off, don't imagine that you are just being suspicious or extra. Take time to pray, ask the right questions and quietly observe patterns till light emerges in your heart.
- **Embrace the Power of Privacy** and make new choices about what you choose to share about your life and journey.
- **Investigate new people, communities, leaders, institutions** etc when they start to make an entry into your world. Be sure to pray about new connections, ask other people in your network and share them with your family as appropriate. Refuse to be a lone ranger!

MORE RESOURCES

- 1 Download **Audio Sermons** by Debola Deji-Kurunmi's Telegram Channel [HERE](#)
 - 2 Take a **Spiritual Growth Course** on FIREBRAND Bible School [HERE](#)
 - 3 Take a **Spiritual Stage Assessment** to know where you are in your Journey [HERE](#)
 - 4 Sign Up to Speak to a **Mature Christian Counselor** [HERE](#)
 - 5 Subscribe and Listen to **Spiritually Maturing Teaching** [HERE](#)
 - 6 Learn **11 Ways to Study the Bible** [HERE](#)
 - 7 **DOWNLOAD FIREBRAND Reawaken 90-Day Devotional** for Personal Revival [HERE](#)
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